



PHOTO BY MILIND SHELTE



IN AUGUST 2025, Priya Nair became Hindustan Unilever Ltd's (HUL's) Chief Executive Officer & Managing Director, one of India's most high-profile corporate roles. She is the first woman to helm the fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) major, a barometer for consumer spending, helped by a large portfolio across product categories and a strong distribution network. In FY25, its turnover was ₹60,680 crore; market capitalisation is well over ₹5.79 lakh crore.

Appropriately, this was 30 years after Nair joined the company straight after MBA from Symbiosis Institute of Business Management in Pune. Through the innings, she moved across categories and countries, leading to a resume that, quite literally, ticked all the boxes for the position.

THE LEARNING CURVE

"If I look back, two moments really shaped the way I think," says Nair. "The first was moving into sales as regional manager for the west. There was no debate on HUL's distribution muscle, with its brands reaching nine out of ten households in India. She maintains it wasn't so much about the numbers but more about understanding how things work on the ground. "I got a real sense of rural distribution, consumer choices and FMCG dynamics in the hinterland, where so many of our customers live," she tells BT.

Nair, who is also a member of the Unilever Leadership Executive, says the other big moment was taking on global responsibilities as Global Chief Marketing Officer for Beauty &

Global Thinking, Indian Touch

Priya Nair—the first woman CEO of HUL—doesn't believe in just numbers. Gaining on-the-ground insights is her priority

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN